STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE			G-7700
	SARPY COUNTY SHERIFF'S OFFICE PAPILLION * NEBRASKA **GREG LONDON** **SHERIFF**	DATE ISSUED 12/04/06	DATE REVISED **06/15/21**	DATE REVIEWED 02/02/25
		APPROVED: *GREG LONDON*		
CHAPTER TITLE GENERAL	RESOURCES CALEA 22.1.5			
SUBJECT SUPPORT SERVICES FOR LINE-OF-DUTY DEATH AND SERIOUS INJURY	CROSS REFERENCE G-7400 PSYCHOLOGICAL SERVICES G-9400 DEATH NOTIFICATION			

I. Purpose:

The purpose of this policy is to establish the guidelines for providing support services to the immediate survivor's of a line-of-duty death, as well as employees who have been seriously injured in the line of duty and their immediate family.

II. Policy:

The Sarpy County Sheriff's Office shall provide support and liaison assistance to the immediate survivors of any active employee of the Sheriff's Office who dies in the line of duty, as well as employees who have been seriously injured in the line of duty and their immediate family.

III. Definitions:

A. BENEFIT COORDINATOR: Employee assigned to assist with the paperwork associated with benefits and insurance.

B. FAMILY SUPPORT ADVOCATE: Employee designated to act as a long-term liaison with the surviving family.

C. FUNERAL LIAISON OFFICER: Employee designated to assist the immediate survivors with matters related to the funeral.

D. HOSPITAL LIASON DEPUTY: Deputy responsible for coordinating the arrival of immediate survivors, law enforcement officers, the media, and others.

E. LINE-OF-DUTY DEATH/SERIOUS INJURY: Any event, criminal or non-criminal which claims the life of, or seriously injures an active employee who was performing a work-related function while on or off duty.

F. **PRIMARY NOTIFICATION DEPUTY:** Command Officer responsible for informing family members of an employee who has died in the line of duty or been seriously injured.

G. **SHERIFF'S OFFICE LIASON:** The Sheriff's Office employee who will make the family aware of all SCSO resources and assistance that is available and coordinate such assistance with the appropriate family representative.

IV. Procedure:

A. Implementation:

1. The ADC shall be notified immediately of a line-of-duty death or serious injury.

a) Communication will be restricted to secure channels of the radio or by phone.

b) The name of the deceased or injured employee will not be released to the media before immediate family members living in the area have been notified.

c) If the media identifies the name of the deceased or seriously injured member, they will be asked to voluntarily withhold the release of that information pending notification of the family. No member of the sheriff's office will give confirmation until such time as proper notifications have been made.

2. The ADC shall immediately notify the command staff and begin the notification process (section B).

3. The ADC shall be responsible for coordinating the implementation of this policy.

B. Notification Procedures:

1. Timely notification is of the utmost importance in the event of a line of duty death or serious injury.

2. The Sheriff or designee will assume the role of Primary Notification Deputy.

3. The Primary Notification Deputy and at least one other SCSO employee will make notification in person.

a) If the employee is in critical condition and survival is in question, notification, and transportation of the family to the employee's location will be made without delay.

~~**b)**~~ If the notification involves a death, an SCSO Chaplain should accompany the Primary Notification Deputy. Notification shall not be delayed if a Chaplain is not immediately available.

4. Considerations:

a) If a family member is known to have a medical condition that may be exacerbated by the notification, medical personnel should be dispatched to accompany the notification team.

b) The notification team should be prepared to make childcare arrangements for families who do not wish to take young children to the hospital.

c) The notification team should be prepared to transport the family members to the hospital. Family members should be strongly discouraged from driving themselves.

5. Notification should be made inside the home, if possible.

a) Notification information should be provided slowly and clearly.

b) The employee's name should be used during notification.

c) Notification should avoid giving a false sense of hope. If the employee has died, the words "died" and "dead" should be used.

d) Individuals completing the death notification who have been affected by the death should feel free to express emotion.

6. Parents of the employee should also be provided an in-person notification if they live in the local area.

7. If the employee's family members are not in the local area, a request for personal notification shall be made to the law enforcement agency in the location of the employee's family members (see G-9400 Death Notification).

8. The Primary Notification Deputy or designee should complete a report documenting which family members were notified and which agencies had been contacted to serve personal notice for out-of-town family members.

C. Assisting the Family at the Hospital:

1. If applicable, the first deputy to arrive at the hospital becomes the Hospital Liaison Deputy and remains as such until relieved of those duties by a command officer.

2. A command officer shall be designated as the Hospital Liaison Deputy and assigned to meet with designated hospital personnel to arrange for an appropriate waiting area for family members. A separate area may be required for Sheriff's Office employees. The Hospital Liaison Deputy should function as a liaison between hospital staff and to ensure the timely relay of pertinent information.

3. The Hospital Liaison Deputy or designee shall be present while the family members are at the hospital and should arrange for whatever assistance they may require.

4. The members of the notification team should be among those employees assisting the family at the hospital.

5. Arrangements should be made for transportation of the family to their residence(s).

6. The Hospital Liaison Deputy shall ensure that all medical bills relating to the services rendered to the deceased employee be sent to the Sheriff's Office.

   a) If the incident occurred outside of normal business hours, the Hospital Liaison Deputy shall contact the billing office during normal business hours to ensure proper billing takes place.

D. Support for Family and Affected SCSO Members

1. Acceptance of Sheriff's Office assistance by immediate family of a member who is killed or seriously injured in the line of duty is voluntary.

2. Within 24 hours of the incident, the Sheriff will designate a Sheriff's Office Liaison (usually the respective Division Commander), a Benefits Coordinator, a Family Support Advocate, and Funeral Liaison if appropriate.

   a) These designations will be announced to SCSO employees via email.

   b) The Sheriff or designee will notify the family of the designated choices.

   c) All referrals will be made according to areas of responsibility.

3. Within 24 hours, the Sheriff or designee will make a request for critical incident stress management debriefing (CISM). See G-7400 Psychological Services.

4. Employee Assistance Program

a) The Employee Assistance Program is a confidential counseling assessment and referral service provided through the Sarpy County Human Resources Department. Employees and their family members may use this program for help with personal, family, or job-related problems.

b) Supervisors may recommend that a member contact the EAP for consultation or members may do so on their own.

5. Chaplain Program

a) The SCSO Chaplains are available for employees and family members.

6. Concerns of Police Survivors

a) Concerns of Police Survivors (COPS) is a non-profit organization that provides additional assistance to disabled law enforcement officers or the survivors of fallen officers in rebuilding their lives.

b) COPS provides educational assistance, counseling, and peer support.

E. Support for Next of Kin During the Funeral and Related Services:

1. The Sheriff's Office shall appoint a Funeral Liaison Officer for the next of kin. The liaison officer should be familiar with the deceased employee's next of kin, but not be so emotionally involved that he/she would be ineffective. The liaison officer shall be responsible for the following:

a) Ensure the needs of the next of kin come before the wishes of the Sheriff's Office whenever possible.

b) Meet with the next of kin and advise them of his or her responsibilities during the period after the employee's death.

c) Meet with the next of kin regarding funeral arrangements. The Sheriff's Office shall provide information to the next of kin regarding a "line-of-duty" funeral. Brief the next of kin on specific funeral

procedures (e.g., 21-gun salute, presentation of the flag, funeral procession, etc.).

d) Be always available to the next of kin by cellular phone.

e) Remain abreast of all information regarding the death and the continuing investigation to provide current information for the next of kin.

f) Assist with arrangements for travel and lodging for out-of-town next of kin.

g) Ascertain the involvement of the Fraternal Order of Police and explain the involvement to the next of kin.

h) Ensure surviving parents and other persons with close relationships to the deceased are afforded recognition and shall be properly placed during the funeral and funeral procession.

i) Initiate contact with Concerns of Police Survivors (COPS), Inc. to provide additional support to the next of kin.

2. The ADC shall be designated to respond to media related concerns. In the event the next of kin should decide to accept an interview, the ADC shall attend the interview and "screen" all questions presented to the next of kin to prevent jeopardizing pending legal proceedings.

3. A Sheriff's Office staff or volunteer psychologist should be made available to the employee's designated next of kin (see G-7400 Psychological Services).

4. The Sheriff's Office shall provide routine checks of the deceased employee's residence for a minimum of six (6) weeks after the incident.

5. The Sheriff and command staff should be in contact with the next of kin during this period.

F. Assistance with Benefits for the Surviving Next of kin:

1. The Sheriff's Office shall appoint an employee to be the Benefit Coordinator for the surviving next of kin. The Benefit Coordinator shall gather information on ALL benefits available to the next of kin. The Benefit Coordinator shall be completely responsible for filing appropriate paperwork for all benefits and shall remain in contact with the next of kin to ensure all benefits are received.

2. The Benefit Coordinator shall visit with the next of kin within a week of the funeral to discuss the benefits they will receive and when they can expect to receive them.

a) The Benefit Coordinator shall visit again with the next of kin within a month of the first visit to ensure benefits have been received and to respond to any questions the next of kin may have regarding benefits.

b) The Benefit Coordinator shall make an additional visit within six (6) months of the initial visit.

3. If there are surviving children from a former marriage, the Benefit Coordinator shall contact the parent or guardian of those children to provide benefit information.

4. The Benefit Coordinator shall pay particular attention to the potential concerns of the next of kin regarding the possible revocation of health insurance.

G. Family Support Advocate:

1. The Sheriff's Office shall appoint a Family Support Advocate who will be the long-term contact between the Sheriff's Office and the family.

2. The Sheriff's Office should be sensitive to the needs of survivors other than a spouse or significant other. Adult-aged children, young children, parents, siblings, and others will experience grief.

a) If plaques or memorabilia are given to the surviving spouse or significant other, consideration should be given to providing similar memorabilia to surviving parents.

b) Children from former marriages should also be considered for plaques or personal memorabilia.

3. Surviving next of kin should be invited to appropriate Sheriff's Office functions.

4. The Sheriff's Office should have monthly contact with the surviving next of kin through the first year and quarterly contact thereafter.

5. Co-workers who were close to the deceased employee are encouraged to have regular contact with the next of kin.

6. The Sheriff's Office shall observe the employee's death date with a short note to the next of kin and/or flowers on the employee's grave.

7. Sheriff's Office personnel should avoid making commitments to the surviving next of kin that may not be met.

8. The Sheriff's Office shall provide support for the next of kin for as long as the next of kin requests support.

H. Next of Kin Support Before and During Trial:

1. If the employee's death resulted from criminal action, the next of kin shall be informed of all new developments regarding the investigation prior to any press release.

2. The next of kin shall be provided all the details of the incident prior to any court proceedings.

3. The liaison officer shall ensure that the next of kin is informed of all trial or parole proceedings.

4. After the trial, the investigators involved shall sit down with the next of kin and answer ALL their questions.

5. The Sheriff's Office shall coordinate with the Victim/Witness Unit to provide additional support for the next of kin during court proceedings.

6. The next of kin shall be encouraged to attend the trial and other court proceedings. The liaison officer shall accompany the next of kin at all court proceedings.

7. Sheriff's Office personnel of all ranks shall also show support for the fallen employee by attending court proceedings.